

13. Strategies & Supports

Terms for documenting what supports were tried and how the child responded.

Document not just what the child did, but what you tried and what made a difference. This is essential information for referrals, family conversations, and team planning.

Environmental Modifications		
reduced visual clutter in work area	offered preferential seating near the adult	provided a quiet workspace
used flexible seating (wobble cushion, floor space)	used natural lighting when possible	reduced background noise during instruction
offered a visual schedule for the routine	posted visual supports at child's eye level	used a first-then visual board
provided a designated calm-down space	offered a transition object	used sensory tools in the environment (fidget, weighted blanket)

Instructional Supports		
broke task into smaller steps	provided a visual model before asking child to try	offered a step-by-step picture guide
used hand-over-hand support	provided wait time before expecting a response	gave one direction at a time
used simple, direct language	repeated directions using the same words	offered choice within the activity
used a timer to signal transitions	provided a 5-minute and 2-minute warning before transitions	used a peer buddy model
incorporated the child's interests into the task		

Relational & Co-Regulation Supports		
adult sat beside child during difficult moment	adult used a calm, quiet voice	adult named the child's feeling aloud
adult offered two choices	adult used a warm and predictable greeting	adult reduced demands during distress
adult provided physical reassurance (if welcomed)	adult used humor to de-escalate	adult narrated the plan ('First we will...')
adult provided genuine specific praise		

Movement & Sensory Supports		
offered a movement break before the task	incorporated movement into the learning activity	provided a sensory bin as a calming option
offered deep pressure activities before demanding tasks	used weighted lap pad	offered resistance band on chair legs
provided proprioceptive input through obstacle course	offered headphones or earmuffs during loud activities	allowed child to use gloves or tools with messy materials
offered alternatives to messy materials		

14. Documentation Phrases & Sentence Starters

Ready-to-use professional language for writing objective observation notes.

Copy or adapt these sentence starters directly into your observation notes. Fill in the bracketed information with specific, accurate details.

Opening an Observation Note	
During [activity/routine] on [date], [child's initials] ____	Over the past [X days/weeks], staff have observed that ____
On [date] at [time] during [activity], the following was observed: ____	This observation was recorded by [initials] on [date] at [time] in [location]. ____
During a [X-minute] observation of [routine], [child's initials] ____	

Describing Frequency & Duration	
This occurred ____ times during the ____ minute observation.	The behavior lasted approximately ____ minutes each time.
Staff have observed this pattern on ____ out of the past ____ school days.	This was the ____ time this week this occurred during [routine].
The child remained [in this state] for approximately ____ minutes before ____	Staff documented ____ separate incidents between [date] and [date].

Describing What Helped	
The child calmed within ____ minutes when ____	The child completed the task after [support] was provided.
When given [strategy], the child [response].	The child responded well to [adult] using a [calm/quiet/warm] voice.
With a visual schedule in place, the child [response].	When offered a choice between ____ and ____, the child ____
After a [X-minute] movement break, the child ____	

Describing What Did Not Help	
Verbal redirection alone did not result in ____	The child did not respond to [strategy] on this occasion.
Repeated verbal prompting did not change the behavior.	The behavior continued despite [support tried].
The child's distress did not decrease when [approach] was used.	

Closing an Observation Note	
Follow-up: [action planned]	This observation will be shared with [family/team] on [date].
Pattern has been noted across [X] observations. Referral is being considered.	Staff will continue to document this pattern and review on [date].
This note has been reviewed by [supervisor initials] on [date].	Observation documented by [initials]. Record stored in [location].

A note on professional responsibility: These word banks are a starting point, not a shortcut. The best documentation is specific, accurate, and grounded in direct observation. Before sharing any observation with a family, re-read it and ask: Does this describe what I actually saw and heard? Does it treat this child and family with dignity? Could I stand behind this professionally? If the answer to all three is yes — it's ready to share.